UNIVERSITY OF ENGINEERING AND TECHNOLOGY, LAHORE.

Course: Psychology (HU-214) Course Instructor: Sehar Farooq

Week: 2
Topic: Personality (Individual Differences)

a. What is personality?

Personality is made up of the lasting traits and patterns that shape how we think, feel, and act in different situations. It is what makes each of us unique. Everyone has their own set of long-term characteristics and ways of interacting with others and the world. Personality is generally stable over time and does not change easily. The word "personality" comes from the Latin word persona.



Happy, sad, impatient, shy, fearful, curious, helpful. What characteristics describe your personality?

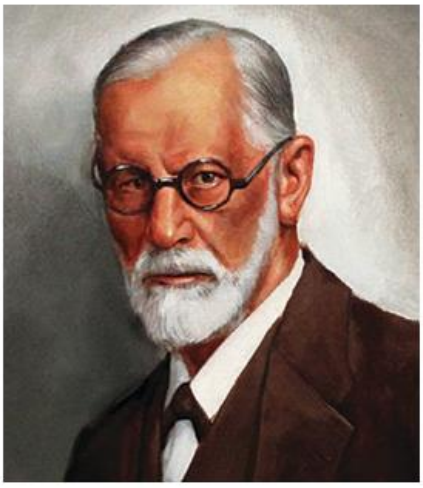
b. Personality: Bio-psycho-social perspective

As studied earlier (Structuralism, Behaviorism, Psychoanalysis), modern-day psychology does not follow a single perspective for personality. Instead, it uses a **biopsychosocial approach**, considering:

- **Biological factors** (brain, hormones, genetics)
- **Psychological factors** (thoughts, emotions, personality)
- **Social and cultural factors** (family, society, culture)

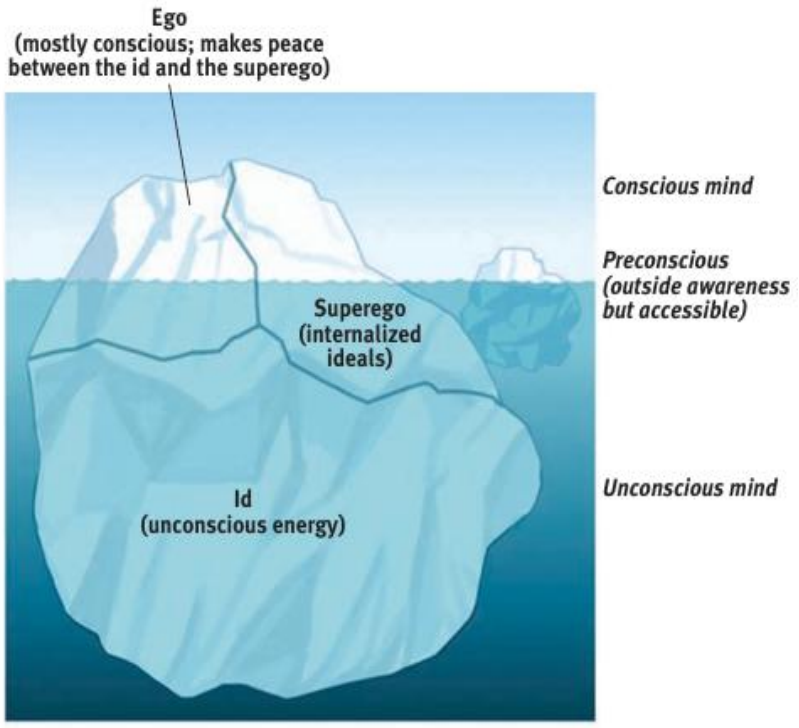
c. Freud and the psychodynamic perspective

Psychodynamic theories view personality with a focus on the unconscious and the importance of childhood experiences. Freud's theory of personality attributes thoughts and actions to unconscious motives and conflicts; the techniques used in treating psychological disorders seek to expose and interpret unconscious tensions.



Sigmund Freud (1856–1939) "I was the only worker in a new field."

In Freud's view, human personality—including its emotions and strivings—arises from a conflict between impulse and restraint—between our aggressive, pleasure - seeking biological urges and our internalized social controls over these urges. Freud believed personality arises from our efforts to resolve this basic conflict—to express these impulses in ways that bring satisfaction without also bringing guilt or punishment. To understand the mind's dynamics during this conflict, Freud proposed three interacting systems: the id, ego, and superego.



The ***id's*** energy constantly strives to satisfy basic drives to survive, reproduce, and aggress. The id operates on the ***pleasure principle***: It seeks immediate gratification.

Ego: the largely conscious, mediates among the demands of the id, superego, and reality. The ego operates on the ***reality principle***, satisfying the id's desires in ways that will realistically bring pleasure rather than pain.

The ***superego, the voice of our moral compass,*** is the part of personality that represents internalized ideals and provides standards for judgment (the conscience) and for future aspirations.

Psychosexual stages of Personality:

Analysis of his patients' histories convinced Freud that personality forms during life's first few years. He concluded that children pass through a series of psychosexual stages, during which the id's pleasure - seeking energies focus on distinct pleasure-sensitive areas of the body called erogenous zones. Each stage offers its own challenges, which Freud saw as conflicting tendencies.

Freud's Psychosexual Stages

Stage	Focus
Oral (0–18 months)	Pleasure centers on the mouth—sucking, biting, chewing
Anal (18–36 months)	Pleasure focuses on bowel and bladder elimination; coping with demands for control
Phallic (3–6 years)	Pleasure zone is the genitals; coping with incestuous sexual feelings
Latency (6 to puberty)	A phase of dormant sexual feelings
Genital (puberty on)	Maturation of sexual interests

d. Neo-Freudians: Adler, Jung, and Horney

Neo-Freudians accepted the role of the unconscious but argued that social, cultural, and interpersonal factors are more important in personality development than Freud's emphasis on sexual and biological drives.

	Theory	Main View of Personality	Key Concept
Alfred *Adler*	Individual Psychology	Personality develops as people strive to overcome feelings of inferiority and achieve success.	Everyone experiences ***feelings of inferiority*** in childhood. Personality develops through efforts to overcome these feelings. ***Birth order*** can influence personality. Healthy people develop ***social interest*** (concern for others).

Carl *Jung*	Analytical Psychology	Personality is shaped by both personal experiences and a shared unconscious inherited from humanity.	Proposed the ***collective unconscious***, containing universal memories called ***archetypes***. Important archetypes: • **Persona** (public mask) • **Shadow** (hidden impulses) • **Anima/Animus** (feminine and masculine aspects) • **Self** (integration of personality) Popularized ***introversion*** *and* ***extraversion***.
Karen *Horney*	Social-Psychological Theory	Personality develops through attempts to cope with anxiety and insecurity in relationships.	Introduced ***basic anxiety***, arising from insecurity in childhood. People cope through three interpersonal styles: **Moving toward people** (compliance) **Moving against people** (aggression) **Moving away from people** (withdrawal) Criticized Freud's concept of "penis envy." Stated that men might suffer from "womb envy".



Alfred Adler "The individual feels at home in life and feels his existence to be worthwhile just so far as he is useful to others and is overcoming feelings of inferiority" (*Problems of Neurosis*, 1964).



Karen Horney "The view that women are infantile and emotional creatures, and as such, incapable of responsibility and independence is the work of the masculine tendency to lower women's self-respect" (*Feminine Psychology*, 1932).



Carl Jung "From the living fountain of instinct flows everything that is creative; hence the unconscious is the very source of the creative impulse" (*The Structure and Dynamics of the Psyche*, 1960).

e. Learning approaches

Among all the learning approaches, the most prominent is Albert Bandura's social learning theory. It proposes that personality develops through observational learning, modeling, reciprocal determinism, and self-efficacy. Individuals adapt behaviors by observing others and evaluating the consequences of those behaviors. Thus, personality is shaped by the interaction of personal factors, behavior, and the social environment.

Bobo Doll Experiment

The Bobo doll experiment, led by Albert Bandura, reveals that children can learn aggressive behaviors simply by observing adults. This study highlights the impact of

observational learning on child behavior, initiating discussions on the influence of media violence. Learn more here: https://www.verywellmind.com/bobo-doll-experiment-2794993

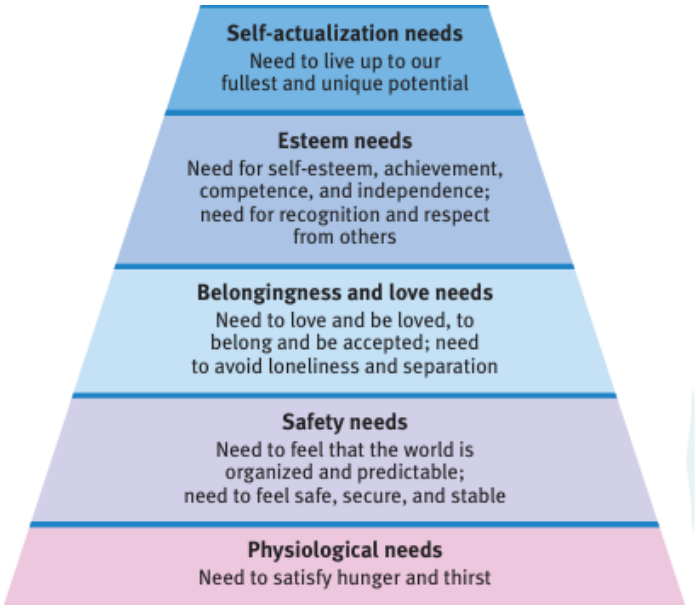
Watch here: https://youtu.be/dmBqwWlJg8U?si=BKnuOpUHcdqoKTDD

f. Humanistic approaches

In contrast to Sigmund Freud's emphasis on disorders born out of dark conflicts, these humanistic theorists focused on the ways people strive for self - determination and self - realization. Unlike behaviorism's scientific objectivity, they studied people through their self-reported experiences and feelings.

Abraham Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs:

Maslow proposed that we are motivated by a hierarchy of needs. If our physiological needs are met, we become concerned with personal safety; if we achieve a sense of security, we then seek to love, to be loved, and to love ourselves; with our love needs satisfied, we seek self - esteem. Having achieved self - esteem, we ultimately seek self-actualization (the process of fulfilling our potential) and self-transcendence (meaning and purpose beyond the self).



g. Biological approaches

Biological factors play an important role in shaping personality.

- Genetic inheritance influences traits such as extraversion, neuroticism, and temperament, which often appear early in life.
- Brain structures and the nervous system also affect personality by regulating emotions, behavior, and responses to stimulation.
- Neurotransmitters, such as dopamine and serotonin, influence mood, motivation, and emotional stability, while hormones can affect aggression, stress responses, and social behavior.
- Additionally, evolutionary psychologists suggest that certain personality traits developed because they enhanced survival and reproductive success.

Together, these biological factors contribute significantly to the development and expression of personality.

h. Trait theorists

Trait theorists believe that personality consists of stable characteristics (traits) that influence how people think, feel, and behave across different situations.

Personality = A collection of enduring traits that vary from person to person.

Unlike Freud, trait theorists focus less on unconscious conflicts and more on measuring and describing personality characteristic.

Theorist	Theory	Main Idea	Key Concepts
Gordon Allport	Trait Theory	Personality is made up of unique traits that distinguish each individual.	Cardinal, Central, and Secondary Traits
Raymond Cattell	16 Personality Factors	Personality can be reduced to a set of basic, measurable traits.	16PF (16 Personality Factors)
Hans Eysenck	Biological Trait Theory	Personality has biological roots and can be described through a few major dimensions.	Extraversion, Neuroticism, Psychoticism
Costa & McCrae	Five-Factor Model (Big Five)	Personality consists of five broad traits that describe most individual differences.	OCEAN Model



i. Cultural understandings of personality

Social and cultural factors play a significant role in shaping personality throughout an individual's life.

- Family interactions, parenting styles, peer relationships, education, and social experiences influence the development of attitudes, values, beliefs, and patterns of behavior.
- Culture provides norms, traditions, and expectations that guide how individuals think, feel, and behave within society. For example, collectivist cultures often encourage cooperation and interdependence, while individualistic cultures may emphasize independence and personal achievement.
- Through socialization, individuals learn acceptable behaviors and develop aspects of their personality that help them adapt to their social environment.

> ***Spotlight effect:*** overestimating others' noticing and evaluating our appearance, performance, and blunders (as if we presume a spotlight shines on us)

Expected Questions

Short Answers

- What is social learning theory?
- What was Alfred Adler's criticism as a Neo-Freudian?
- What was Carl Jung's criticism as a Neo-Freudian?
- What was Karen Horney's criticism as a Neo-Freudian?
- Write about any two trait theorists and their proposed concepts.
- What are the Big Five personality factors?

Long Answers

- Explain the Psychodynamic perspective of personality by Sigmund Freud.
- What are the psychosexual stages of personality development?
- What is Abraham Maslow's hierarchy of needs? In your point of view, how can one reach self-actualization in today's world?
- Differentiate between biological and cultural perspectives of personality; how do they affect and shape personality?